

1. Sample 1 of water froze at 0°C .
2. Sample 2 of water froze at 0°C .
3. Sample 3 of water froze at 0°C .
-
- N. Sample N of water froze at 0°C .
- N+1. If all past samples of water froze at 0°C , then
this sample of water will freeze at 0°C .
-
- C. This sample of water will freeze at 0°C . (1-N+1)

Is this argument valid?

We already have an explanation of why we should believe premises 1-N.

What about premise $N+1$?

In our first reading, Hume addresses the question of whether we should believe premises like this by drawing a distinction between two different kinds of claims:

Premise N+1 appears to be like the claim that the sun will rise tomorrow:
it is a matter of fact rather than a matter of the relations of ideas, and so
cannot be known "by the mere operation of thought."

$N+1$. If all past samples of water froze at 0°C , then this sample of water will freeze at 0°C .

The Uniformity of Nature

The future will be like the past.

It seems as though, if we should believe in the Uniformity of Nature, we should believe $N+1$. So the basic question is whether we should believe in the Uniformity of Nature.

Is the negation of this claim a contradiction?

It seems not. So it seems that, if we should believe it, we must believe it
on the basis of experience.

After all, yesterday the future was like the past. And the same for the day before that. And this suggests an argument for the Uniformity of Nature.

1. Yesterday, the future was like the past.
2. The day before yesterday, the future was like the past.
3. The day before the day before yesterday, the future was like the past.

.....

N. N days ago, the future was like the past.

C. Today, the future will be like the past. (1-N)

It is hard to see how we could make the argument valid without adding a premise which was just a restatement of the very claim — the Uniformity of Nature — which we were trying to prove.

All massive objects
attract one another.

Every 24 hours, the earth
rotates on its axis.

It is very plausible that these are all claims which we should believe. But we have at present no explanation of this fact. After all, the only arguments we can give for these claims will be arguments like our argument that the sun will come up tomorrow. And these arguments are invalid, and hence not good arguments. This seems to show that

Foundationalism, as we have formulated it, is false.

Halley's comet will next be visible
from earth in 2061.

It also raises an important question. We think that at least some scientific theories are theories we should believe, and that other generalizations are not. Consider, for example,

People born under the sign of Taurus
are more likely to be stubborn than
people born under other signs.

This is a prediction of the theory of astrology. One shouldn't believe this prediction because one shouldn't believe the theory. But why not?

It is tempting to say something like: there's no good argument for astrology; there's no reason to think that it is true.

That leads to our central question: what does it mean for a theory to be **well-supported** by the evidence?

The examples we have already discussed give us a plausible answer to this question. Scientific theories typically involve certain generalizations. In the simplest case, they will be claims of the form

All F 's are G .

These are not claims which our senses can tell us to be true. But our senses can tell us that claims like this are true:

This particular
thing is an F ,
and it is G .

Let's call claims which are related in this way to generalizations **instances** of the
generalization.

Then we might say that a generalization is well-supported by the evidence just in case the following two conditions are satisfied:

Our senses tell us
that many instances
of the generalization
are true.

Our senses don't tell us that any instances of the generalization are false.

Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you know many true instances of a generalization P , and don't know of any false instances of P , you should believe P .

I want to now look at two problems for Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief.

The first is called the paradox of the ravens. Consider the following

generalization:

All ravens are black.

All non-black things are non-
ravens.

This is a serious problem for our rule of Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief, since it looks like after Investigation #2 I should **not** form the belief that all ravens are black.

Suppose that I now begin to investigate my immediate environment for non-black things, checking whether they are ravens. I check my shirt, the lectern, my laptop — and it turns out that none of them are ravens.

It is also, indirectly, a problem for our idea that we could fix the problems with Foundationalism by adding other kinds of good beliefs to the original three categories. For if Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief is not true, we still lack an explanation of why we should believe that the sun will come up tomorrow.

The core of foundationalist views is the idea that we can list the good kinds of belief, and then adopt a negative principle which says that any beliefs not on the list should be rejected. We have not shown that this general idea is incorrect. But we have shown that it is harder to come up with the list of good beliefs than one might have thought.

We already have an explanation of why we should believe premises 1-N.

What about premise $N+1$?

believe premises like this by drawing a distinction between two different

In our first reading, Hume addresses the question of whether we should

kindest of claims:

Premise $N+1$ appears to be like the claim that the sun will rise tomorrow:

it is a matter of fact rather than a matter of relation as, and so

cannot be known 'by the mere operation of thought.'

in the Uniformity of Nature.

should believe $N+1$. So the basic question is whether we should believe

It seems as though, if we should believe in the Uniformity of Nature, we

It seems not. So it seems that, if we should believe it, we must believe it

on the basis of experience.

before that. And this suggests an argument for the Uniformity of Nature.

After all, yesterday the future was like the past. And the same for the day

of Nature — which we were trying to prove.

premise which was just a restatement of the very claim—the Uniformity

It is hard to see how we could make the argument valid without adding a



All massive objects
attract one another.



Every 24 hours, the earth
rotates on its axis.

Foundationalism, as we have formulated it, is false.

claims will be arguments like our argument that the sun will come up tomorrow. And

present no explanation of this fact. After all, the only arguments we can give for the

It is very plausible that these are all claims which we should believe. But we have at

these arguments are invalid, and hence not good arguments. This seems to show that



Halley's comet will next be visible
from earth in 2061.

It also raises an important question. We think that at least some scientific theories are

theories should believe, and that other generalizations are not. Consider, for example,



People born under the sign of Taurus
are more likely to be stubborn than
people born under other signs.

because one shouldn't believe the theory. But why not?

This is a prediction of the theory of astrology. One shouldn't believe this prediction

It is tempting to say something like: there's no good argument for astrology; there's no

reason to think that it is true.

That leads to our central question: what does it mean for a theory to be well-

supported by the evidence?

visibility of the form

The examples we have already discussed give us plausible answers to this question.

Scientific theories typically involve certain generalizations. In the simplest case, they

All F 's are G .

These are not claims which our senses can tell

us that ain't like this are true:

This particular
thing is an F ,
and it is G .

Let's all claim which are related in this way to generalizations of the

generalization.

case the following two conditions are satisfied:

Then we might say that a generalization is well-supported by the evidence just in

Our senses tell us
that many instances
of the generalization
are true.

Our senses don't tell us that any instances of the generalization are false.



Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you know many true instances of a generalization P , and don't know of any false instances of P , you should believe P .

The first is called the paradox of the ravens. Consider the following

generalization:



All are abba.



IRVING

All non-blacks things are non-

black.

like after Investigation #2 I should not form the belief that all ravens are

This is a serious problem for our rule of Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief, since it looks

whether they are raven's. I check my shirt, then, my laptop — and it turns out that none of

Suppose that I now begin to investigate my immediate environment for non-black things, checking

then are ravens.

three categories. For if Induction $\rightarrow$ Belief is not true, we still lack an

explanation of why we should believe that the sun will come up tomorrow.

It is also, indirectly, a problem for our idea that we could fix the problems

with Functionalism by adding other kinds of gods to the original

on the list should be rejected. We have not shown that this general idea is

incorrect. But we have shown that it is harder to come up with the list of

of belief, and then adopt a negative principle which says that any beliefs not

The core foundationalist view is the idea that we can list the good kinds

good beliefs than one might have thought.



you rises don't tell you that P

No Foundation → No Belief

If you can't be certain that P and

argument for P , you should not

Dei ieiunare.

and you can't give a good